ENGLISH B2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Narrative tenses

Coordinate past simple, past continuous and past perfect to organise foreground events, background action and earlier causes. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use narrative tenses to guide the reader through the sequence and viewpoint of a past narrative while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Coordinate past simple, past continuous and past perfect to organise foreground events, background action and earlier causes.

MODEL

The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door.

past perfect = earlier | past continuous = background | past simple = event line

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main narrative tenses patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses guide the reader through the sequence and viewpoint of a past narrative.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in stories, incident reports, biographies and spoken anecdotes.

Build meaning before form

Coordinate past simple, past continuous and past perfect to organise foreground events, background action and earlier causes.

What narrative tenses communicates

Coordinate past simple, past continuous and past perfect to organise foreground events, background action and earlier causes.

The central purpose is to guide the reader through the sequence and viewpoint of a past narrative. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The lights went out and the audience became silent.	completed events that move the narrative forward
People were leaving when the announcement began.	an activity already in progress around a shorter event
The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door.	an event completed before the current past viewpoint

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: past perfect = earlier | past continuous = background | past simple = event line. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Event line	past simple	The lights went out and the audience became silent.
Background process	past continuous	People were leaving when the announcement began.
Earlier cause	past perfect	The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
completed events that move the narrative forward	Event line
an activity already in progress around a shorter event	Background process
an event completed before the current past viewpoint	Earlier cause

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in stories, incident reports, biographies and spoken anecdotes. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03
past perfect = earlier	past continuous = background	past simple = event line

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: guide the reader through the sequence and viewpoint of a past narrative.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits stories, incident reports, biographies and spoken anecdotes.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Event line	past simple	The lights went out and the audience became silent.
Background process	past continuous	People were leaving when the announcement began.
Earlier cause	past perfect	The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The lights went out and the audience became silent.	completed events that move the narrative forward
People were leaving when the announcement began.	an activity already in progress around a shorter event
The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door.	an event completed before the current past viewpoint

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not overuse past perfect after the earlier sequence is already clear.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use past continuous for every consecutive finished event.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use past simple when the earlier relationship would become unclear.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: completed events that move the narrative forward?

OPTIONS The lights went out and the audience became silent. · People were leaving when the announcement began. · The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an activity already in progress around a shorter event?

OPTIONS People were leaving when the announcement began. · The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door. · The lights went out and the audience became silent.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an event completed before the current past viewpoint?

OPTIONS The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door. · The lights went out and the audience became silent. · People were leaving when the announcement began.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The lights went out and the audience became silent.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS completed events that move the narrative forward · an activity already in progress around a shorter event · an event completed before the current past viewpoint

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “People were leaving when the announcement began.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an activity already in progress around a shorter event · an event completed before the current past viewpoint · completed events that move the narrative forward

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an event completed before the current past viewpoint · completed events that move the narrative forward · an activity already in progress around a shorter event

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"The lights went out and the audience became silent." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Event line / Background process / Earlier cause · Gap 2: completed events that move the narrative forward / an activity already in progress around a shorter event / an event completed before the current past viewpoint

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"People were leaving when the announcement began." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Background process / Earlier cause / Event line · Gap 2: an activity already in progress around a shorter event / an event completed before the current past viewpoint / completed events that move the narrative forward

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Earlier cause / Event line / Background process · Gap 2: an event completed before the current past viewpoint / completed events that move the narrative forward / an activity already in progress around a shorter event

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses completed events that move the narrative forward: _____. Choose the model that expresses an activity already in progress around a shorter event: _____. Choose the model that expresses an event completed before the current past viewpoint: _____. Choose the model built with past simple: _____. Choose the model built with past continuous: _____. Choose the model built with past perfect: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

People were leaving when the announcement began. · The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door. · The lights went out and the audience became silent.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The lights _____ and the audience became silent. People _____ when the announcement began. The alarm was ringing because someone _____ the rear door. State the full structural pattern for Event line: _____. State the full structural pattern for Background process: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The lights failed; then the audience reacted.” using the Event line pattern to express completed events that move the narrative forward.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The leaving was in progress when the announcement started.” using the Background process pattern to express an activity already in progress around a shorter event.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The door was opened first; that caused the alarm.” using the Earlier cause pattern to express an event completed before the current past viewpoint.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The lights failed; then the audience reacted.” using the Event line pattern to express completed events that move the narrative forward.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Event line to express completed events that move the narrative forward, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Background process to express an activity already in progress around a shorter event, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Earlier cause to express an event completed before the current past viewpoint, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The lights went out and the audience became silent.

Event line is the best match because completed events that move the narrative forward.

A2

People were leaving when the announcement began.

Background process is the best match because an activity already in progress around a shorter event.

A3

The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door.

Earlier cause is the best match because an event completed before the current past viewpoint.

A4

completed events that move the narrative forward

The Event line pattern communicates completed events that move the narrative forward.

A5

an activity already in progress around a shorter event

The Background process pattern communicates an activity already in progress around a shorter event.

A6

an event completed before the current past viewpoint

The Earlier cause pattern communicates an event completed before the current past viewpoint.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Event line / completed events that move the narrative forward

The structure belongs to the Event line pattern. Its communicative purpose is completed events that move the narrative forward.

B2

Background process / an activity already in progress around a shorter event

The structure belongs to the Background process pattern. Its communicative purpose is an activity already in progress around a shorter event.

B3

Earlier cause / an event completed before the current past viewpoint

The structure belongs to the Earlier cause pattern. Its communicative purpose is an event completed before the current past viewpoint.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The lights went out and the audience became silent.

Event line: past simple.

C2

People were leaving when the announcement began.

Background process: past continuous.

C3

The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door.

Earlier cause: past perfect.

C4

The lights went out and the audience became silent.

Event line: past simple.

C5

People were leaving when the announcement began.

Background process: past continuous.

C6

The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door.

Earlier cause: past perfect.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

went out

Event line requires “went out” in this model. past simple.

D2

were leaving

Background process requires “were leaving” in this model. past continuous.

D3

had opened

Earlier cause requires “had opened” in this model. past perfect.

D4

past simple

Event line is built as past simple.

D5

past continuous

Background process is built as past continuous.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The lights went out and the audience became silent.

past simple. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended event line effect.

E2

People were leaving when the announcement began.

past continuous. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended background process effect.

E3

The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door.

past perfect. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended earlier cause effect.

E4

The lights went out and the audience became silent.

past simple. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended event line effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The lights went out and the audience became silent. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses past simple accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

People were leaving when the announcement began. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses past continuous accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The alarm was ringing because someone had opened the rear door. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses past perfect accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____